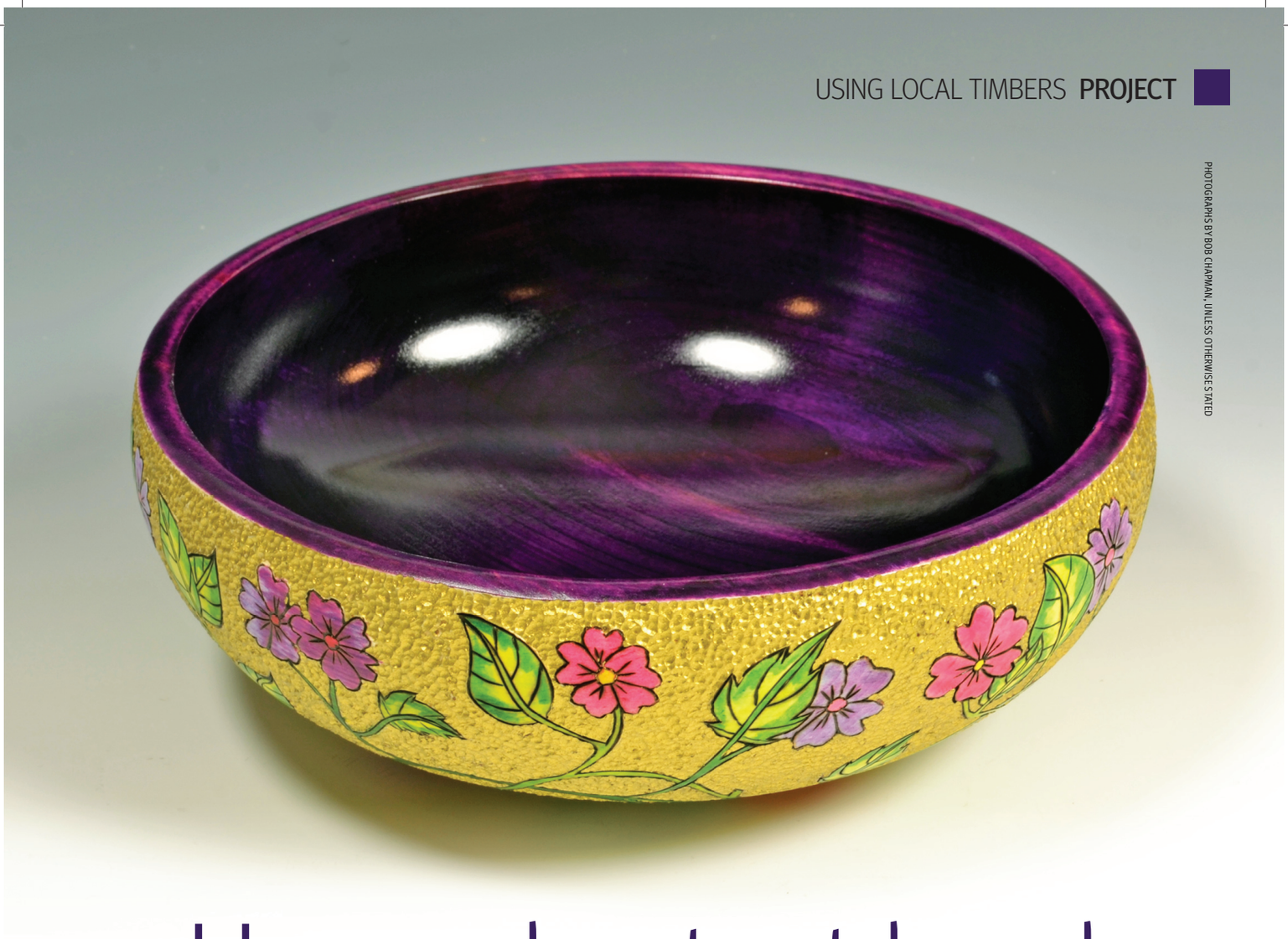

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Horse chestnut bowl

Bob Chapman explains how he turned a decorative bowl from a tricky piece of horse chestnut

BOB CHAPMAN

After teaching chemistry for many years, Bob took early retirement to become a professional woodturner, and is a member of the Register of Professional Turners. He was a demonstrator at the 2009 AWGB Woodturning Seminar and is available for commissions.

bob@bobchapman.co.uk
www.bobchapman.co.uk

Horse chestnuts (*Aesculus hippocastanum*) are thought to originate from Greece and Albania and were probably introduced into Britain as ornamental trees sometime in the early 17th century. The timber is soft, weak and decays easily. As a result it has no constructional value but finds some use in packing cases and pallets. It is an absorbent timber and is used for fruit storage boxes where it keeps fruit dry and prevents decay. Extracts from horse chestnut leaves and nuts are said to have anti-inflammatory properties and are used in herbal remedies. In the USA the trees are known as 'buckeye' because the fruits resemble a deer's eyes.

In the UK the nuts of the horse chestnut are commonly called 'conkers' and that name is also often used to describe the tree itself and the timber obtained from it. British school children have long played a game where the conkers are threaded on strings and struck against each other until one is smashed to pieces. During both world wars, British children were urged to collect conkers which could be processed to produce acetone, an essential solvent in the manufacture of explosives.

In Britain the term 'conker' is used to refer both to the nuts and timber of the horse chestnut tree

The horse chestnut's flower spikes are called 'candles'

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